

Q How should I prepare for a feeding and what are the best positions?

Make sure you are comfortable and well supported when you settle down into a feeding session. This is key to making sure that breast-feeding goes smoothly. If it is likely to be a fairly lengthy session, make sure you have a snack and beverage on hand.

Since you will be spending a considerable amount of time sitting still while your baby nurses, you need to make sure that your upper back, shoulders, and neck aren't strained, and that your lower back and arms feel supported. If you are slouched, it can lead to back and shoulder pain and make it harder for your baby to latch on well, which in turn can result in sore nipples and other breast-feeding problems. Tension resulting from bad posture could impede your flow of milk.

Sit in a firm-backed chair, or use cushions to support your lower back so that you can hold an upright posture throughout the feeding. Try not to hunch your shoulders, which we tend to do when we are tense; instead, consciously bring them down, which is instantly relaxing.

It is possible to breast-feed twins at the same time, for example by using the football hold position (see below). Seek advice from a breast-feeding consultant about breast-feeding twins.

FEEDING POSITIONS

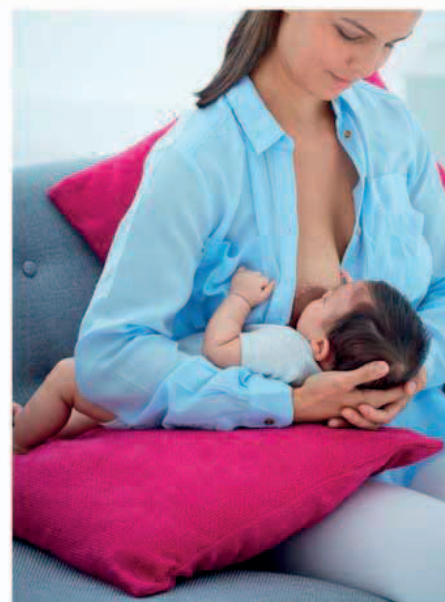
How you position your baby at the breast can help him nurse effectively and prevent sore nipples. If your breasts feel a bit tender or your nipples are sore, alternating positions from one feeding to another will make sure pressure is more evenly distributed around the nipple area (areola).



Cradle hold Sitting upright, hold your baby with his tummy facing your tummy, supporting his back and bottom. You may find it helpful to put a cushion on your lap to support your arm and your baby's weight throughout the feeding.



Reclining Hold or cradle your baby so that he is completely supported by you. You may find that this is a good position for night feedings. Support your back with pillows or cushions so that you are comfortable as you recline in this semi-upright position.



Football hold This position can work well after a C-section, since it prevents putting pressure your abdomen, or for feeding twins. Put your baby on a cushion, on the side he will nurse from, that supports his whole body. Support his head with your hand.



Side by side Lie on your side with your baby facing you. You may want a pillow behind you for support or to raise your body by lying on a folded blanket or towel. Prop yourself up on your elbow, or rest your head on your forearm, then use your free hand to support your baby's head and upper body and gently guide him to the breast. This relaxing position is ideal for the first feeding following a cesarean section, and while recovering from a C-section, because it avoids putting any pressure on your abdomen, and of course is perfect for nighttime feeding.